PASTRY CREAM

MAKES	ACTIVE TIME	REST	TOTAL TIME
600 ml	**25 min**	**10 min off the heat, then chilled**	**40 min plus chilling**

INGREDIENTS

480 ml	Whole milk
1/2 bean	Vanilla bean
1/4 tsp	Salt
115 g	Sugar
30 to 35 g	Cornstarch
2	Eggs, large
60 g	Unsalted butter

METHOD

1. Set a bowl on the counter and rest a fine-mesh sieve in its rim. The cream lands there later, so it needs to be ready before anything goes on the heat.
2. Measure the milk into a heavy saucepan, anything but aluminium. Split the half bean lengthwise, scrape the seeds out with the tip of a knife straight into the milk, and add the salt.
3. Bring the milk up over medium-high heat to just short of boiling. Stir every so often and sweep the base of the pan, because the solids settle there and scorch. A bigger batch needs more attention.
4. Meanwhile whisk the sugar and cornstarch together in a mixing bowl. Take the full 35 g of cornstarch for a firm cream that holds a cut slice, and 30 g for everything else.
5. Break the eggs in and whisk until no lumps remain.
6. Ladle roughly a third of the scalding milk into the eggs in a slow stream, whisking the whole time. A lightly damp towel under the bowl steadies it and frees both hands.
7. Return it to the remaining milk on the stove. Whisk over a medium flame for roughly 2 minutes, until the body matches softly whipped cream.
8. Bring it just to the edge of a boil so the starch cooks out fully. A few slow bubbles breaking the surface is the target. A hard boil will curdle it.
9. Take the pan off the heat at once and push the cream through the sieve into the waiting bowl. Left sitting in the hot pan it keeps cooking.
10. Give it 10 minutes to drop in temperature, stirring now and then so heat escapes and no skin sets on top.
11. Cut the butter into four pieces. At around 60C, whisk them in one at a time, each piece disappearing completely before the next goes in.
12. Press plastic wrap flat against the surface of the cream and refrigerate. To cool it fast, spread it in a shallow dish first and wrap it the same way.

NOTES

Never use an aluminium pan. The yolks react with the metal and the cream turns grey.
Scorched milk ruins the whole batch and cannot be rescued. If dark spots appear on the pan bottom, taste the milk and start over if it has gone acrid.
The gap between properly thick and curdled is a matter of seconds. A cream that has gone only slightly grainy will sometimes come back with an immersion or countertop blender, though not reliably.
Two whole eggs give a lighter cream than the all-yolk French versions. Four yolks in place of the eggs makes a richer one.
Whisking the cream once it is cold breaks the starch down and thins it, so handle it gently from then on. Well covered, it keeps 5 days in the refrigerator.

DATE ___ / ___ / ___ RATING ___ / 5 OVEN ADJ _____

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